



Block 'em

There are many ways to block IM traffic. You could just block/disable the protocol ports from your proxy or NAT server. A LAN Domain Controller can prevent IM software from being installed or used. A really adamant systems / network administrator can ensure that no employee connects to any IM networks, ever! However, instant messaging has become more a part of our lives than we realise. Many employees use IMs to chat with clients—it's free, instantaneous, and nowhere as close to invasive as a phone call. So the new problem for both small / medium businesses and enterprises is not how to block IM access, but how to regulate it.



Suggested Software

Symantec IM Manager (www.symantec.com): What was once a free software called IM Logic has been bought over by security specialists Symantec and made into a security solution for any business. If you're worried about IMs being a security risk, or just a productivity killer, this is a solution you'll love as a boss and hate as an employee. The software sits on a server and can log all IMs your employees send. It can block IMs that contain certain phrases (in real-time), block file transfers or just certain file types, it logs everything that's said in IM form, and generates reports as basic as who (user ID and IP) chatted how long and to how many people, to reports that will give you usage patterns and the exact messages sent. It can connect to a SQL database and store all information there, so admins can just search for keywords or users and get detailed information. It is also very legally-aware, and informs users and the people they speak to of its presence, so no lawsuits will ruin that sweet taste of victory over IMs. If anything can stop your employees from goofing off and chatting all day, IM Manager can. Just send your employees a mail informing them of your decision to install this software (with a link to the homepage) and your productivity should increase instantaneously. It's not cheap, obviously, and you can expect to shell out \$40 (Rs 1,800) per license (per user) for small-sized organisations, or \$30 (Rs 1,350) for enterprises.



P2P

Here in India, a lot of employees take advantage of the fat Net pipe that companies provide, and use it to download illegal software and content using P2P networks. Apart from increasing a company's Internet bill, the illegal use can land a company with a slew of lawsuits. P2P software are known to tunnel (bypass restrictions by using another protocol's ports), and can even use normal HTTP ports (80) or POP ports (110 or 25). Basically, if you're connected to the Net, chances are your employees can use P2P software and access networks to download illegal content.



Stop Piracy

As mentioned, blocking P2P is a lot harder than anything else mentioned before. Thankfully there's software available that will put your mind at ease. Such software is rarely cheap, however.



Suggested Software

IM Lock Professional (www.comvigo.com): Yes, we know. This does fit into the category of an IM blocker, and the name suggests that's all it does... However, IM Lock is much more than just an IM blocker. This software is a little more expensive than Symantec's IM Manager, but it's primarily a blocker, not a "Manager". It can block access to all known IM networks, Web-based IM services, streaming media sites, and yes, almost every known P2P protocol and related sites. So if BitTorrent is the bane of your existence, get this and live peacefully, because it will block not just the entire Torrent protocol, but also access to any site that has

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